

Write the exceptions down

You go looking for the one process and find ten versions of it, none written down, all kept in people's heads. A person uses judgment and fills those gaps without noticing. **An agent follows the process exactly as written.** It can't treat this vendor as a special case unless that case is **written down as a rule.**



THE FOUR MOVES THAT ACTUALLY STANDARDIZE A PROCESS in order

- I

Make it visible
The real process on one page, exceptions included.
 - If your map leaves out the exceptions, it isn't accurate.
- 2

Kill the exceptions you can
Most of them have no good reason left.
 - Many exceptions no longer have a reason, like a special path set up in 2019 for someone who has since left.
- 3

Codify the ones that survive
Write each one down as a rule.
 - "Over this amount, second approval." An agent can follow that rule because someone wrote it down.
- 4

Make it the default
One standard way, unless a codified reason says otherwise.
 - It has to be how the work actually runs, every day.

Visible, reduced, codified, default. **None of the four moves involves the AI model;** all four are about how the work runs. ("Forty-seven" is a figure of speech from the episode. Your own count is the number that matters.)

WHAT AN AGENT DOES WITH AN EXCEPTION NOBODY WROTE DOWN two outcomes

It stops
A person now has to watch every run, which is the manual work the automation was meant to remove.

It doesn't stop
It applies the normal path to a case that needed an exception, and pays an invoice that should have been held.

When the rule is missing, the agent still takes one path. **Nobody chose that path,** and the exceptions were never counted, because to the people running the process they aren't exceptions, just "how we do it".

"But our business is too complex to standardize." That objection is why the mess never gets fixed. Standardizing means writing each exception down as a **rule**, and you can keep the ones you need. The judgment moves out of one person's head and into the system, so the work is done the same way whoever is in that day.

Monday morning YOUR FIRST MOVE

Take the one process you're most tempted to automate, the boring, high-volume one, and **count the paths.** Pull twenty or thirty real cases from last month and trace what actually happened to each, whatever the document says should have happened.
One, two or three distinct routes and you're ready to automate it. Fifteen, and the first job is standardizing the process, before any AI. When the document and the count disagree, go with the count.

OPERATOR INSIGHT · LAYER 3

Standardize before you automate - or you don't get one process running fast, you get forty-seven. The chaos, industrialized.
"Your AI maturity will never exceed your operational maturity."

Free

Score your own processes – the AI-Ready Operations Assessment runs all five layers as a readiness check, on a scale from "ad hoc" to "AI-ready". vihrenlabs.gumroad.com/l/rmkje